THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

Written by

Tendai

Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
2026

FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. Down through the cold, toward the light, the way a thing comes home.

The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into the room. The quiet of something that has been going on for hours.

Two mugs on the side table. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it.

MAYA, 30s, on the sofa, feet tucked under her, wearing his coat. Too big in the sleeves. Her face is lit blue by her phone. Thumb moving. She has been scrolling for a long time.

JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, drying a mug. At home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases.

Maya scrolls. Looks up at him. Scrolls.

MAYA
(not looking up)
That's the same mug.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
The mug. You've done that one about... six times.

JAMES
It's still wet.

MAYA
It's really not.

He keeps drying it. She keeps scrolling.

JAMES
There was a heron on the tarn this morning.

MAYA
On the what?

JAMES
The tarn. The -- lake thing. The little lake.

MAYA
Oh. Yeah. You said.

JAMES
Same spot as yesterday. Just stood there.

MAYA
You said that as well. In the car. And at lunch. And in the, the shop, you told the woman in the shop.

JAMES
She was interested.

MAYA
She was not interested, James, she was being paid.

JAMES
It's a good heron.

MAYA
It's an incredible heron. I'm thrilled for it.

Scroll. He has moved on to wiping a counter that is already clean.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Is the heating on?

JAMES
It's on.

MAYA
It doesn't feel on.

JAMES
It's on, it's -- it takes a while. It's old.

MAYA
Mm.

Scroll.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You going to keep doing that?

JAMES
Doing what?

MAYA
That. Whatever that is.

JAMES
I'm tidying.

MAYA
It's a holiday let. Someone comes and cleans it on Thursday. That's what we paid for.

JAMES
(not quite under his breath)
I paid for.

It comes out before he can stop it. Small. Petty. She stops scrolling.

MAYA
Wow.

JAMES
I didn't --

MAYA
No. Okay. No, you did, it's fine, I'll -- what was it. Four hundred? I'll transfer you.

JAMES
Maya, I didn't mean --

MAYA
Half of four hundred. Two hundred. Yeah.

She taps at the phone with her thumb, too hard.

JAMES
Will you stop --

MAYA
Done. Sorted. We're square.

He puts the cloth down. Comes through. Sits. The armchair, not the sofa. She clocks the distance. Goes back to her phone.

He settles. And then, quiet, barely there, to the empty end of the sofa nearest him, almost a smile:

JAMES
(barely)
Shove up.

Her thumb stops.

She looks at the empty cushion. Then at him.

MAYA
What did you say.

JAMES
Nothing.

MAYA
You said shove up.

JAMES
I didn't say -- did I? I don't know. It's just a thing, it's a --

MAYA
Don't. Don't. I know what it is. I know exactly what it is.

He rubs his face. Half a second where even he isn't sure. Gone again.

She puts the phone face down on her knee. First time tonight.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
Oh here we go.

MAYA
Two. And the second one's sweet. Two sugars. You don't, you don't take sugar, you've never once -- not once, since I've known you, and you stood there, you stood there stirring two sugars into a cup for --

JAMES
It's a cup of coffee, Maya.

MAYA
IT IS NOT A CUP OF COFFEE.

It rings off the stone walls. She hears herself.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(lower, fast)
You asked me to come. You did. I didn't, I didn't invite myself. You said come up for a few days, it'll be good, it'll be quiet --

JAMES
It is quiet.

MAYA
It's so quiet, James. It's the quietest place I've ever been in my life.

She stands. Walks, because she can't sit. Picks up one of his jumpers off the back of a chair and folds it without thinking, the way you fold something you've folded a hundred times. Puts it down.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Do you know what it's like. Trying to -- with someone who isn't even here. Compete. With. I can't win it, there's no -- she doesn't get to annoy you. She doesn't get old. She doesn't fold your stuff wrong, she doesn't -- she just gets to be gone. And perfect. And I'm the one who's -- I'm here. I'm the one still here.

JAMES
Don't.

MAYA
At least if she was alive I could hate her prop --

She stops. Too late. It is out.

JAMES
(quiet, and cold)
Say that again.

MAYA
I didn't --

JAMES
No, go on. Say it again.

MAYA
I didn't mean it. James. I didn't, that's not what I --

JAMES
Yes you did. You did. You keep a little list, don't you. The sugars. The coffees. Who I'm looking at. Like you've got some sort of right to it.

That one finds the exact spot. She goes very still.

MAYA
Haven't I?

He doesn't answer.

He doesn't answer, and the not answering is the loudest thing in the room.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Right.

JAMES
That's not what I --

MAYA
No, I heard you. I heard you fine.

She crosses to him. Takes his face in both hands. Hard.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Look at me. Look. Am I here? Am I actually in the room with you, or am I just, what, sat on the end of it --

He looks. And for one second he is completely there, and she hates how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes slide. Past her. To nothing. She feels his face turn under her hands toward the empty air.

She lets go like it burned her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(a laugh that isn't one)
There. There it is. I've got my -- my hands are on your face and you still went.

JAMES
(worn through)
I know. You've said. You say it every time.

MAYA
So stop doing it.

JAMES
You think I'm doing it on purpose? You think I want to --

MAYA
Then put it down. Put it -- one night. One. And just be here. With me. Like you said. You said you would.

JAMES
It's not that --

MAYA
Don't. Don't say it's not that simple. It is. You could. You choose it, every time, every single time you choose it over me and then you call it, what, something that's happening to you --

JAMES
(up, loud)
It IS happening to me!

MAYA
Then let me in! Once. Just let me into the -- whatever it is, the room, just --

JAMES
There isn't a room --

MAYA
There's always a room. There's always some room you're in and I'm -- I'm never -- not once. Not once, James.

Silence. She is breathing hard. She looks down at the phone still in her hand. Turns it round so he can see the screen.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There's a train from Oxenholme. Twenty to eight. I've been looking at it for an hour.

He looks at the screen. Then at her.

JAMES
Then get it.

Flat. Like he knows she won't. Like she always stays.

MAYA
(barely)
You think I won't.

He doesn't answer that either.

And then, because he said it, because he can't take it back and can't stand it, he crosses to her. Not to comfort her. To stop the moment existing. It isn't tender, it's a collision. She shoves him in the chest, hard, then grabs a fistful of his shirt and hauls him back in. Two people who know each other's bodies better than they know what they are to each other.

For a second it might be enough.

Then she feels it. His breath at her ear, his face turned away. She opens her eyes.

He is looking past her. Over her shoulder. At the room. Holding her, and gone.

She shoves him off.

MAYA
You're -- even now. Even now, James. I've got my hands on you and you're still --

She can't finish it. She's shaking.

He is already half-turned back toward the space.

JAMES
(to it, lost)
I don't even know if you're --

He can't finish either.

He drifts to the window and opens it again, without knowing he's done it. The cold comes back in.

MAYA
You've opened it again. James. Look what you're doing.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the empty air beside him. Palm open. At a height. For a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. His own hand. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The open window. Maya, in his coat. The empty end of the sofa. The whole shape of it, all at once.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and breaks.

MAYA
(small now, frightened)
James.

He isn't looking at her. He's looking at the air. He backs away from it, and it comes after him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(pleading, to no one she can see)
Not now. Not tonight. Go on.
Please. Please, just go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

And there it is. The full size of it, in her face.

JAMES
(a roar, torn out of him,
at nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. Back, hard, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. The gold window shrinking below.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high over the roof. Looks down.

At the small lit cottage. At the one warm window. At the man inside it, tiny now, both hands over his face.

And Maya behind him, still in his coat, her phone lit in her hand. Not going to him. Not leaving either. Watching the man she loves shake at an empty room, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look at a place you have just been put out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.